

History-maker



- First Manchester City player to win the Ballon d'Or
- Second defensive midfielder to ever win the trophy
- Second native Spaniard to win the Ballon d'Or
- Youngest recipient since Lionel Messi in 2015
- Third player from the Premier League to win the trophy



Perfect pivot: Rodri brought balance to Spain's midfield. Pics: AFP

Rodri.

"Rodri is the best midfielder in the world right now. He's unbelievable; he's really able to do everything," Guardiola recently said in a press conference. "Remember — what we've done, without him... it would've been difficult." Positioned ahead of the back four, Rodri acted as a pivot and a convergence point for attacks, with Ilkay Gundogan and Kevin De Bruyne waiting for his passes in the final third. **After Gundogan's departure, Rodri also ventured into offensive positions, catching opponents off-guard since they rarely marked a defensive midfielder.**

"I was a traditional midfielder, but I knew I needed to be better in the final third, so I worked on that. That's the modern holding midfield role; you have to be like a striker because you play in the front," Rodri said.

Last season, he set a Premier

League record for the most successful passes across the pitch, with over 2,000 passes in the opponent's half — another record.

In the UEFA Champions League last season, he employed line-breaking passes to counter opponents' pressing tactics, making 100 such passes in the group stages alone — the most by any player that season.

On a night when Real Madrid chose to boycott the ceremony, Rodri's win carved a new path of inspiration for midfielders — to play, strive, and ultimately find glory.

"I would like to tell you a story that led me here. When I was 17, I packed my suitcase to fulfil a dream. One day, I cried to my father, it's all over, I invested my life to get here and that was it," Rodri said.

"My father said, 'We came all the way here, let's keep going'. This is something that changed my mindset. I'm just a normal kid with values; I know what a hard worker is. Thank you very much."

